

veloping for printing presses and packaging materials. Acorn bought Krones (a German firm) and Nordson (a U.S. company)—both makers of packaging and labeling machines—and Komori Printing Machinery (Japan). Making out well with U.S. cellular phone stocks led us to Securicor, a U.K. company; and the success of Wace, an electronic typesetting company in the United Kingdom, told us to look at a similar U.S. company, Devon Group. That's the way it often is these days.

Vanity, No Bonfire

Every public company must have a stock symbol, of no more than four letters. Since there is an unlimited supply of companies to take public, but only a limited number of four-letter codes, the investment banking profession has had to deal with a major challenge.

We can quickly illuminate the critical nature of the ticker-symbol shortage by focusing on the laser industry. Many start-up companies have used laser technology, so the ticker symbols in use include

LASR	LASX
LASE	LSR
LAZR	LSER

There aren't many other ways to almost spell "laser." The next wave of laser companies kept the *L*—LPAC, LMTS, LSCP, and LSRI—but didn't sound very lasery. A linguistic breakthrough was required, and American ingenuity succeeded! Summit Technology found BEAM, and Helionetics coined the immortal ZAP.